In Chandni Chowk, my former journalist colleague Ashutosh was contesting on an AAP ticket. There was still some goodwill for AAP, but this wasn't a Delhi assembly election but a national referendum. The local shopkeepers verdict was emphatic—'We tried Congress, we tried AAP, now only Modi for India!'

Ironically, the only city where I noticed a slightly divided opinion was Amritsar in Punjab where Modi confidant Arun Jaitley was contesting a Lok Sabha election for the first time, against former Punjab chief minister Amarinder Singh. Jaitley could have stood from a Delhi constituency but the fear of the AAP had led him to look for a 'safe' seat. Akali MP Naresh Gujral convinced him that Amristar, with the backing of the Badal family, was the right choice. Jaitley's wide circle of high-powered friends had all descended from Delhi to express solidarity with their *yaar*. It almost seemed like a *baraat* for a *shaadi*, with Jaitley as the *dulha*. While covering the constituency, I would often bump into someone from Delhi. 'We all hope Arun wins, he's such a nice guy,' was a shared feeling. I wondered, though, how their presence was really helping his campaign since a number of them seemed more intent on discovering Amritsar's best kulcha chole joints! By contrast, driving in convoy with his turbaned posse in the city of the Harmandir Sahib, Amarinder Singh looked every inch the Sikh-of-the-soil.

Indeed, on the ground in Punjab, it was apparent that the Modi wave had hit a bit of a wall. At a popular dhaba in the heart of Amritsar, I drank a cool glass of excellent lassi with a group of morning walkers. The dominant sentiment was anti-Akali more than pro-Modi. The local leaders, I was told, were disgustingly corrupt. 'Yes, we want Modi as prime minister. Jaitley is also good, but first we need to teach the Badal government a lesson,' was a common refrain. The Akalis were accused of promoting the worst form of family raj where their relatives monopolized all state resources. It was another telling reminder that the Indian voter cannot be taken for granted. Jaitley may have moved to Amritsar from Delhi to escape the AAP factor, but it was in Punjab that the AAP's anti-corruption plank would resonate